

SOCIAL DIMENSIONS OF EDUCATION (COMPETENCY 1.3)

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COMPETENCY 1.3 Analyze the Historical, economic, socio-cultural, geographical environmental, political and socio-psychological factors that influence the school as an agent of change and the teacher as a facilitator of learning

TOPICS

I. Socio-Cultural Dimensions/Socio-Psychological Dimensions

II. Historical Dimensions/Economical Dimensions/Political Dimensions/Geographical-Environmental Dimensions

I. SOCIO –CULTURAL & SOCIO-PSYCHOLOGICAL DIMENSIONS OF EDUCATION

OVERVIEW

The sociologists offered different theoretical perspectives that are anchored on the concept that school is an open system, to explain the relationship between the school and the society. The diverse sociological explanations enable educators to understand how the school, as a social institution of society, interact with the social environment as they perform their important role in their unique way either as agents of cultural and social transmission or as agents of social transformation. (Social Dimensions In Philippine Education, p.27)

FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS

1. What are the main elements of sociology of education?

Main Elements of the Sociology of Education

- ≡ Theories about the relation between school and society
- ≡ Whether schooling makes a major difference in individuals' lives
- ≡ How schools influence social inequalities
- ≡ How school processes affect the lives of children, teachers, and other adults

2. What are the four levels of sociological analysis?

Four Interrelated Levels of Sociological Analysis

- ≡ The Societal level and its system of social stratification
- ≡ The Institutional level, including families, schools, churches etc.
- ≡ The Interpersonal level, including processes, symbols and interactions
- ≡ The Intrapsychic level, including individual's thoughts, beliefs, values

3. What is Sociology?

Definition of Sociology

- A. The study of human behavior in society.
- B. A scientific way to think about society and its influence on humans.
- C. Includes the study of social behavior and social change.

4. How does Sociologists view education?

The Nature of Education

Sociology provides educators a special perspective in studying the relationship between school and society. Schools, by their very nature are social organizations. (Ballantine, 1989) Because of the nature of education, the study of school systems becomes the concern of sociologists. Sociologists study the social issues and concerns in education which impact on socialization. (Bago, p.1)

5. What are the two basic roles of schools according to Sociologists?

The Role of Schools

Dr. Adelaida Bago, in her book *Social Dimensions in Philippine Education*, stresses that there are two possible purposes or roles of schools:

1. There are those who believe that one role of the school is to educate citizens to fit into society;
2. There are those who believe that the role of the school is to educate citizens to change the society.

6. What are the specific purposes of school in different dimensions?

The specific purposes of the school are the following:

- a. Cognitive Purposes – teaching the basic cognitive skills such as reading, writing, and speaking.
- b. Political Purposes – inculcation of patriotism or loyalty to the existing political order.
- c. Social Purposes – concerns with the socialization of citizens into their various roles in society.
- d. Economic Purposes – involves training and preparation of citizens for the world of work.

7. What do we mean by “school as open system”?

Schools as Open System

Schools are open systems that draw their inputs and send back their outputs to the environment. (Bago, p 6) An open system, like a living organism, has a homeostatic nature. Homeostasis is the property of open systems to regulate its internal environment to maintain stable constant condition. This is done through internal regulation mechanisms of inter-related and interacting parts that counteract any departure from the normal or usual.

8. How do we understand the individual actions of students?

Individual Actions of students

- ≡ Determined by external forces (determinism)
- ≡ Freely shaped by individuals (voluntarism)
- ≡ Sociological perspective recognizes free will within the context of the power of external circumstances, often related to group differences within social stratification system

9. How does the school function as a formal organization?

Schools as Formal Organizations

1. Bureaucratization of Schools

a. Weber noted five characteristics of bureaucracy:

- Division of labor
- Hierarchy of authority
- Written rules and regulations
- Impersonality
- Employment based on technical qualifications

2. Teachers: Employees and Instructors

- a. Teachers' academic assignments have become more specialized but still must control social order
- b. 20% of new teachers quit within 3 years
- c. Fewer students choose teaching as career due to perceived low income

10. How does schooling affect individuals?

Effects of Schooling on Individuals

- a. Knowledge and Attitudes
- b. Employment
- c. Education and mobility, the “civil religion”... education amount vs. route...for the middle class, education may be linked to mobility but for the rich and the poor, it may have very little to do with it

11. What is the function of theoretical / sociological perspectives in the study of education?

THEORETICAL PERSPECTIVES

To provide logical explanations for why things happen the way they do in group situations, sociologists make use of theoretical perspectives. These theories also become the basis for analyzing curriculum, instruction and structure in the school organization. (Bago, p.5) The functionalists and Conflict Theories focused on macro –level of sociological analysis, while the interaction theory focuses on the micro level analysis.

12. What is basic theory of functionalism?

The Functionalist Theory (otherwise known as equilibrium theory). The key terms in this theory are interdependence and consensus. The consensus is the normal state of society (Ballantine, 1989) Social equilibrium is achieved through the process of socialization of members into the basic values and norms of particular group so that consensus is reached. The different parts or members of the society are interdependent, grouped, and organized to form a system.

Functional Theories...stresses the interdependence of the social system, how well the parts are integrated with each other.

13. According to functionalists, what are the two primary functions of a school?

- Manifest functions include:
 - Transmission of knowledge
 - Bestowal of status
- Latent functions include:
 - Transmitting culture
 - Promoting social and political integration
 - Maintaining social control
 - Serving as agent of change

14. How is functionalism applied to education?

The Functionalism applied to education:

- a. Transmitting Culture
Exposing young people to existing beliefs, norms, and values of their culture
- b. Promoting Social and Political Integration
Common identity and social integration fostered by education contribute to societal stability and consensus
- c. Maintaining Social Control
Schools teach students punctuality, discipline, scheduling, and responsible work habits, and how to negotiate through a bureaucratic organization
- d. Serving as an Agent of Change
Schools serve as meeting ground where people can share distinctive beliefs and traditions

15. How does Talcott Parson view society?

Talcott Parsons – conceptualized society as a collection of systems within systems. (McLeland, 2000)

16. How Does Talcott Parson view Education?

Talcott Parsons (a functionalist) writing in the 1950's and 1960's developed Durkheim's ideas. He said education is a key component of the social body, just like the heart is integral to the functioning of the human body, education is fundamental to the health of the social body.

It does this by:

1. Passing on society's culture – education functions as a key mechanism (functional prerequisite) through which a new generation of children acquire the 'central' norms, values and culture of their society. This unites or glues people together by giving them shared values, what sociologists' term as a value consensus, through the 'hidden curriculum'.
2. Socialization – Durkheim argued that schools are a 'society in miniature' – a small scale version of the wider society in which people live and work. Talcott Parsons argued how schools from this standpoint, take over the primary socialization role of parents. This means schools are sites of secondary socialization. They, the schools, provide a bridge between the 'particularistic' values of the family and the 'universalistic' values of meritocracy of contemporary industrial society.
3. Providing a bridge the particularistic values and universalistic values. Particularistic values are those given to you by your family, they treat you as an individual, they take account of your own individual skills, abilities, and habits and from these particularistic values your status within the family has been ascribed. In contrast universalistic values are those given to everyone, the same rules apply to everyone. As an individual you aren't afforded any special considerations and your status is now achieved rather than ascribed. Therefore you might have a high ascribed status at home but a low achieved status at school because you never do any work.
4. Providing a trained and qualified labor force – schooling provides society with people equipped with the right skills to do the jobs society needs. This makes sure the best and most qualified people end up doing the jobs that utilizes and recognizes these skills, qualifications and individual effort. This creates what is termed as the division of labor – whereby the world of work is fragmented into a large number of specialized jobs. From this position the inequalities in society are fair and just, everyone is given an equal chance, it's merely that some people work hard and succeed and others choose to be idle, mess about in class and only have themselves to blame for their failure. Therefore people who work hard at school become dentists while those that don't become binmen – known as meritocracy. Which one are you?
5. Meritocracy– Davis and Moore (functionalists) said as we know live in a meritocratic society the education system becomes the best mechanism for selecting the right people for the right jobs – role allocation. Meritocracy is the notion that people should and are duly awarded by society for their hard work and efforts. Those that work hard will and can achieve those that choose not to, achieve their due rewards.

17. How does Emile Durkheim view education?

In Emile Durkheim's view, educational systems reflect underlying changes in society because the systems are a construct built by society, which naturally seeks to reproduce its collectively held values, beliefs, norms, and conditions through its institutions. Thus, as time unfolds, educational systems come to contain the imprint of past stages in the development of society, as each epoch leaves its imprint on the system. By uncovering these imprints and analyzing them, the development of a society can be reconstructed from the educational system.

18. How is education related to morality according to Emile Durkheim?

Emile Durkheim – believed that education plays a significant role in creating moral unity, which is an imperative in social cohesion and harmony. (Bago, p.10) Durkheim defined education and the concerns of sociology as follows: "Education is the influence exercised by adult generations on those that are not yet ready for social life. Its object is

to arouse and to develop in the child a certain number of physical, intellectual and moral states which are demanded of him by both the political society as a whole and special milieu for which he is specifically destined...” (Ballantine, p.7)

Emile Durkheim stressed that education in all societies of critical importance in creating moral unity, social cohesion, and harmony...moral values are the foundation of society.

19. What is conflict theory?

Conflict Theory – assumes a tension in society and its parts due to competing interest of individuals and groups. Adherents of this theory argue that what holds society together is economic, political, cultural, military power, and not shared values alone. The social order is based on the stability of dominant groups to impose their will on others who are powerless. (Bago, p.13) The Conflict theory is based on four interlocking concepts: competition, structural inequality, revolution, and war. Karl Marx – the founder of the conflict school of thought believed that because the class system separates the employers from workers and workers from the benefits of their own labor, class struggle is inevitable. According to hi, inevitably, the workers would overthrow the capitalists and establish a new society where the proletariat could freely avail of the benefits of their labor.(Conflict Theory, 2000)